

A manoeuvre which calls for skill and timing

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Tennis has its tweener, cricket its no-look boundary, basketball its fade-away

three-pointer. These moves look spectacular and bring the crowd to its feet. They are played with a combination of spontaneity and mischief. None of these humiliates the opponent (who might even applaud).

But there's one manoeuvre in sport which calls for skill and timing and also brings the crowd to its feet. However it leaves the opponent with egg on his face, his dignity dripping. This is football's nutmeg, where the ball is played through an opponent's legs and retrieved on the other side. When the ball goes through your legs, it takes your pride with it, as one player said.

The king of the nutmeg, Brazil's Ronaldinho (**in pic**) once nutmegged two defenders in a match; and once nutmegged the same man twice.

"Nutmegs, for me, are a beautiful thing to do," Javier Pastore, the former Argentina international has been quoted as saying. "They're beautiful to watch. In fact, even when I get nutmegged myself I find that beautiful — and that actually happens quite a lot too!"

Whether the word derives from the spice trade or is a tribute to Cockney rhyming slang, the fact remains that nearly every football culture has a word for it, thus attesting to the universality of the move. It is *caneta* in Brazil, *huacha* in Peru, *salad* in Jamaica, *klobbi* in Iceland, *panna* in the Netherlands, *yalli* in Senegal, *cueca* in Portugal. Goals may win matches, but



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nutmegs win hearts.

The nutmeg demands proximity. You must be close enough to look your opponent in the eye, to sense the weight on his feet, to anticipate the slight widening of stance that opens the door. The defender, momentarily split into two halves by a rolling ball, stands as a metaphor for the game

itself — caught between control and chaos.

Get it wrong, and it transforms from art into folly. This is equally true of the tweener and all those personal touches that raise the routine to the extraordinary.

Coaches frown, teammates groan, and the same crowd that cheered your daring now questions your judgement. This is the tightrope every expressive athlete walks: the balance between invention and indulgence.

"I tried to nutmeg him. It never came off and he gave me a slap on the back of the head and told me to start behaving," wrote Steven Gerrard of his attempt to nutmeg Gazza.

Still, the nutmeg persists as a stubborn relic of joy. It asks a simple question: why just go past a defender when you can go through him? Why play safe when you can be spectacular?

With Ronaldinho, the nutmeg was not an occasional flourish, it was almost punctuation. The ball seemed to obey impulses others could barely imagine. He *wanted* the crowd to gasp. The nutmeg became a personality trait, a signature tune.

When he played the tweener at the 2009 U.S. Open, Roger Federer called it "the greatest shot of my life." Make of that what you will.